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Research on Budgeting Apps	2
Introduction.....	2
Money Tracker (Expense & Budget)	2
Strengths.....	3
Weaknesses	3
Innovative Features.....	3
Monarch Money	4
Strengths.....	4
Weaknesses	5
Innovative Features.....	5
YNAB (You Need A Budget).....	5
Strengths.....	6
Weaknesses	6
Innovative Features.....	6
Infographic Comparison	6
Best Features to Include in My App	7
Conclusion	7
References	7
PART 2: PLANNING & DESIGN	8
Introduction.....	8
App Name:	8
Concept:	8
Icon Idea:	8
Innovative Features	8
Functional Requirements.....	9
Non-Functional Requirements	9
Screens	9
Navigation Flow	10

Research on Budgeting Apps

Introduction

Mobile budgeting applications have become important tools for managing personal finances. With the rise of digital banking and online transactions, many individuals struggle to keep track of their income, expenses, and savings. Budgeting apps help users monitor their spending habits, set financial goals, and gain better control over their finances.

Android smartphones provide access to a wide range of budgeting applications designed to simplify financial planning. These apps typically allow users to link bank accounts, categorize transactions, track expenses, and create financial goals.

This research focuses on three popular budgeting apps available for Android:

- Money Tracker
- Monarch Money
- YNAB (You Need A Budget)

Money Tracker (Expense & Budget)

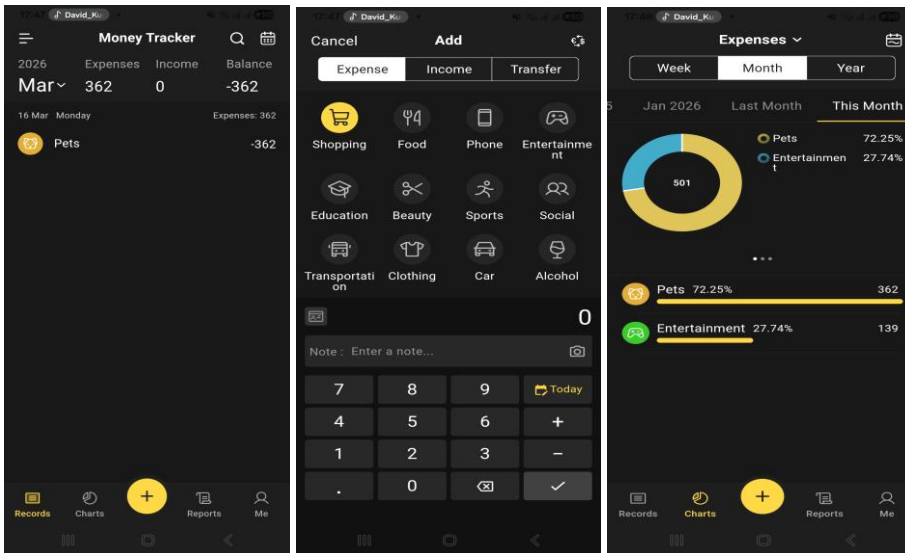
Money Tracker Expense & Budget is a personal finance application developed by Horoscope365. The app is designed to help users track their income and expenses efficiently through a clean and simple interface.

Through the application, users may classify expenditures, keep track of transactions, and use graphic reports to examine financial data. Additionally, it offers integrated tools like calculators and editable templates to improve the flexibility of budgeting.

With more than 5 million downloads and a high user rating of roughly 4.9 stars, the app demonstrates excellent user happiness.

Key features include:

- Expense and income tracking
- Budget management
- Visual reports and charts
- Built-in calculator
- Customizable templates
- Personalized financial insights



The main screen of the app displays a clean interface with categorized expenses and a summary of income and spending. The app uses Dark colors and simple icons to improve usability. Additional screens show charts and expense breakdowns, helping users visualize their financial habits.

Strengths

- Easy-to-use interface suitable for beginners
- Built-in calculator for quick financial calculations
- Personalized insights to help users understand spending
- Custom templates for flexible budgeting

Weaknesses

- Limited advanced financial planning features
- May lack investment tracking
- Requires manual input for transactions
- Some features may require in-app purchases

Innovative Features

- Built-in calculator for quick expense calculations
- Template-based budgeting system for customization
- Personalized insights based on spending behavior
- Simple visual design that improves usability

Monarch Money

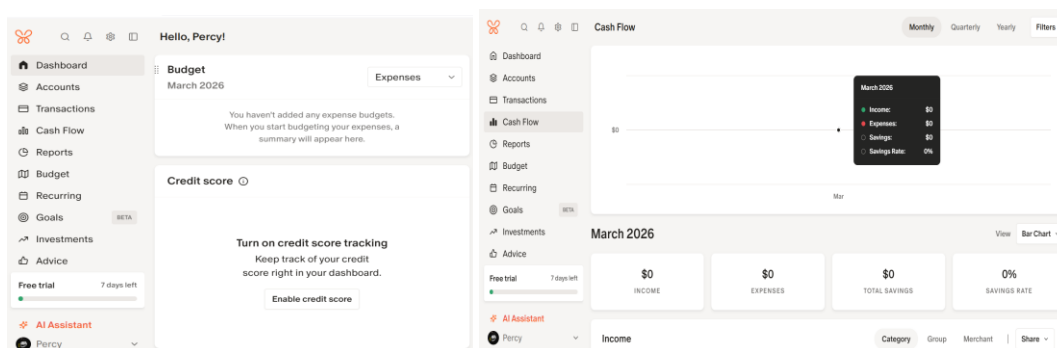
Monarch Money is a modern financial management application that allows users to track spending, manage budgets, and plan financial goals. The app provides a comprehensive dashboard where users can connect multiple financial accounts and track their net worth. (Forbes Advisor, 2025)

The app supports budgeting categories, financial forecasting, and detailed reporting through visual charts and graphs.

Key features include:

- Budget tracking
- Financial goal planning
- Investment tracking
- Cash-flow forecasting
- Subscription tracking

Users can also collaborate with partners or financial advisors within the app to manage finances together. (Money Tracker-Expense & Budget, 2025)



Displays net worth, spending, and financial summary.

Shows categorized budgets and monthly limits.

Visualize future financial trends based on spending.

Strengths

1. Customizable dashboard

Users can personalize their dashboard with widgets and financial reports.

2. Goal-based budgeting

The app allows users to set savings goals such as buying a house or going on vacation.

3. Financial forecasting

Monarch provides projections for future spending and cash flow.

4. Account integration

The app connects with multiple financial institutions and services.

Weaknesses

1. Subscription cost

The app costs around \$14.99 per month or \$99.99 per year, which may discourage some users.

2. Limited credit monitoring

The app does not include built-in credit score tracking.

3. Syncing issues

Some users report occasional problems connecting bank accounts.

Innovative Features

- **Cash-flow forecasting**

The app predicts future spending patterns based on historical data.

- **Collaborative budgeting**

Couples or families can manage finances together using shared accounts.

- **Subscription detection**

The app automatically identifies recurring subscriptions and bills.

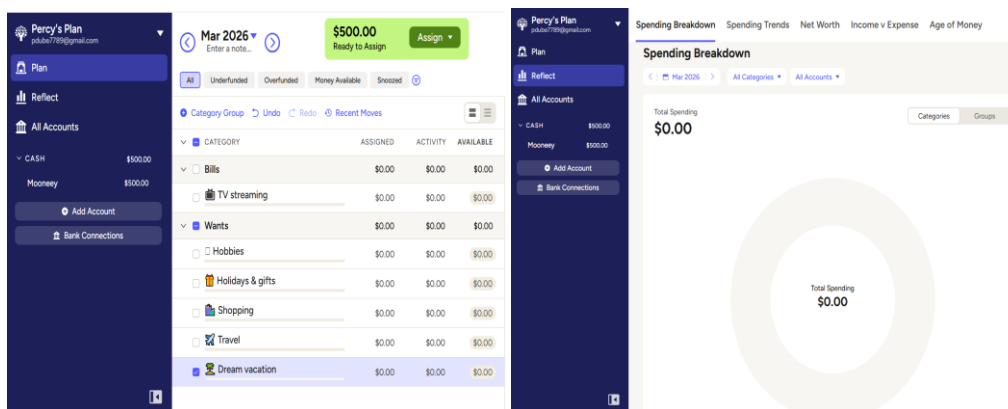
YNAB (You Need A Budget)

YNAB is a popular budgeting application based on the zero-based budgeting method, where every dollar is assigned a specific purpose.

The app focuses heavily on financial discipline and encourages users to allocate money to categories such as rent, groceries, and savings before spending it.

YNAB helps users:

- Assign every dollar a job
- Track spending
- Adjust budgets as circumstances change
- Build long-term financial habits



Shows how money is assigned to categories.

Displays progress toward savings goals.

Shows detailed spending activity.

Strengths

1. **Strong budgeting methodology**

YNAB encourages users to allocate every dollar intentionally.

2. **Financial education**

The platform provides tutorials, workshops, and guides.

3. **Real-time expense tracking**

Users can track transactions instantly through the mobile app.

4. **Goal tracking**

Users can set savings goals and monitor progress.

Weaknesses

1. **Steep learning curve**

New users may find the budgeting system complicated at first.

2. **Limited investment tracking**

YNAB focuses on budgeting rather than full financial management.

3. **Mobile limitations**

Some advanced features are only available on the desktop version. (House of Biblical Wisdom, 2024)

Innovative Features

- Zero-based budgeting system
- Educational financial workshops
- Goal-based financial planning

Infographic Comparison

FEATURE	MONEY TRACKER	MONARCH	YNAB
Ease of Use	High	Medium	Medium
Bank Syncing	No	Yes	Yes
Offline Use	Yes	No	Limited
Goal Tracking	Basic	Advanced	Strong
Forecasting	No	Yes	No
Gamification	No	No	No
Reports	Good	Excellent	Good

Best Features to Include in My App

From the analysis, the following features should be included:

- Simple dashboard (Money Tracker)
- Financial forecasting (Monarch)
- Goal-based budgeting (Monarch + YNAB)
- Zero-based budgeting (YNAB)
- Offline functionality (Money Tracker)
- Reports and charts (All apps)
- Notifications and alerts
- Gamification elements

Conclusion

Budgeting applications are essential tools for financial management. Each app analysed offers unique strengths.

Money Tracker focuses on simplicity and offline access. Monarch Money provides advanced planning tools and forecasting. YNAB emphasizes disciplined budgeting and financial education.

By combining these strengths, a new budgeting app can be designed to be both powerful and easy to use. This research provides a strong foundation for the design and development of such applications.

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PART 2: PLANNING & DESIGN

Introduction

This document outlines the design of a budgeting application inspired by existing apps. The goal is to create an app that is simple, effective, and engaging for users.

App Name:

Pocket Flow

Concept:

A clean, beginner-friendly budgeting app that combines simplicity with powerful insights.

Icon Idea:

- A white icon wallet with a blue and green background color

Innovative Features

- Gamified savings system
- Smart spending alerts
- Offline mode
- Simple dashboard
- Progress levels (like a game)

Functional Requirements

- User registration and login
- Add income and expenses
- Categorize transactions
- Set budgets
- View reports and charts
- Set financial goals
- Notifications for overspending

Non-Functional Requirements

- Easy to use interface
- Fast performance
- Secure data storage
- Offline capability
- Responsive design

Screens

1. Login Screen

Purpose: Allow user access

Description:

The Login Screen enables users to securely access their accounts using their credentials. It includes input fields for email and password, along with options such as “Forgot Password” and “Sign Up” for new users. The design is simple and focused to ensure quick and easy access while maintaining security.

2. **Dashboard**

Purpose: Show financial summary

Description:

The Dashboard serves as the main hub of the application, providing an overview of the user's financial status. It displays key information such as total balance, income, expenses, and recent transactions. Quick action buttons allow users to navigate important features like adding transactions, viewing reports, and managing budgets.

3. **Add Transaction Screen**

Purpose: Input expenses/income

Description:

This screen allows users to record financial transactions by entering details such as amount, category, date, and type (income or expense). It is designed for speed and simplicity, enabling users to quickly log their spending or earnings to maintain accurate financial records.

4. **Budget Screen**

Purpose: Manage spending limits

Description:

The Budget Screen allows users to set spending limits for different categories such as food, transport, and entertainment. It provides visual indicators, such as progress bars, to show how much of the budget has been used. This helps users monitor their spending and avoid exceeding their limits.

5. **Reports Screen**

Purpose: View charts and trends

Description:

The Reports Screen presents financial data through visual charts such as pie charts and bar graphs. It helps users analyze their spending patterns, compare income and expenses, and identify trends over time. This information supports better financial decision making.

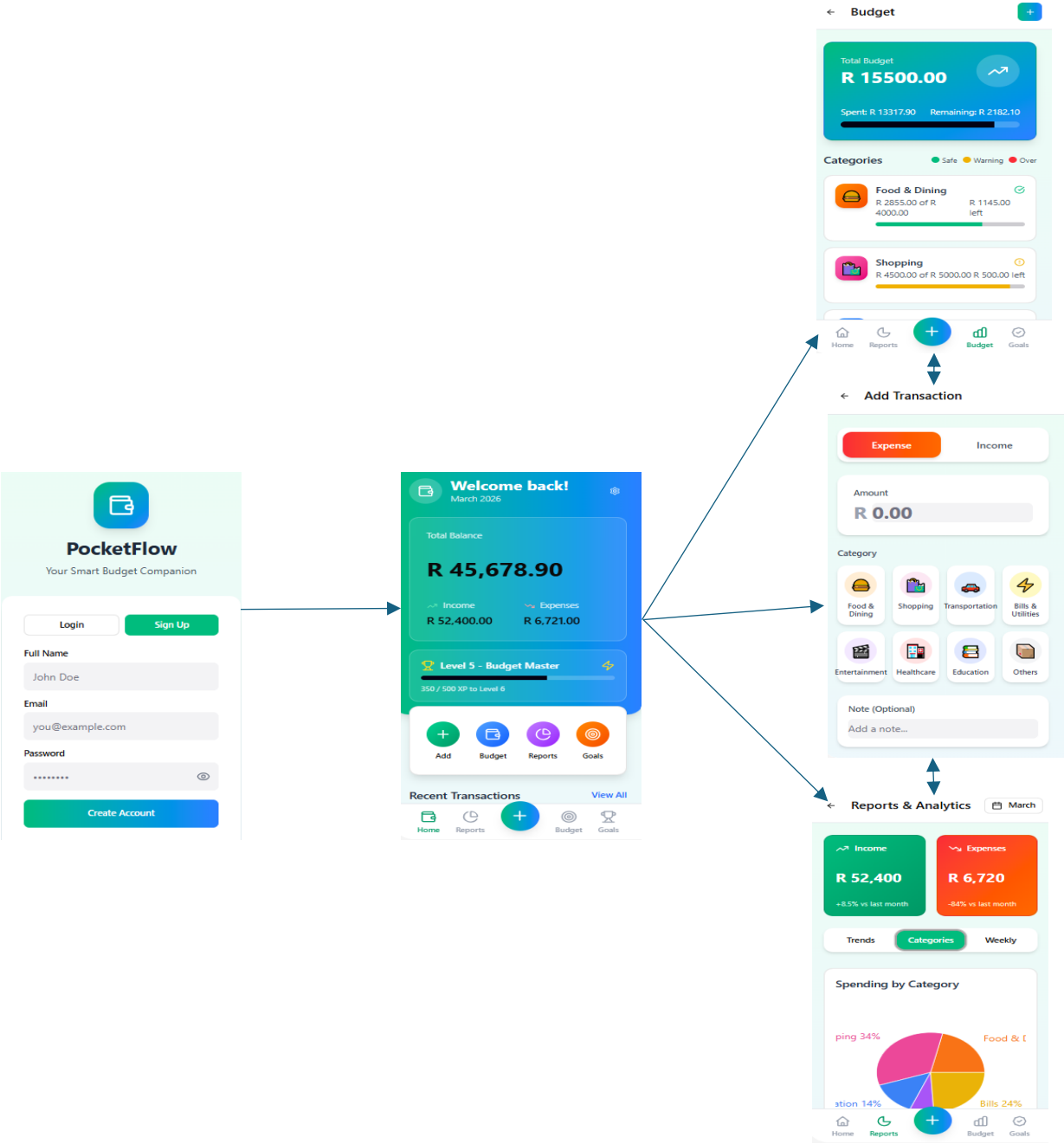
6. **Goals Screen**

Purpose: Track savings progress

Description:

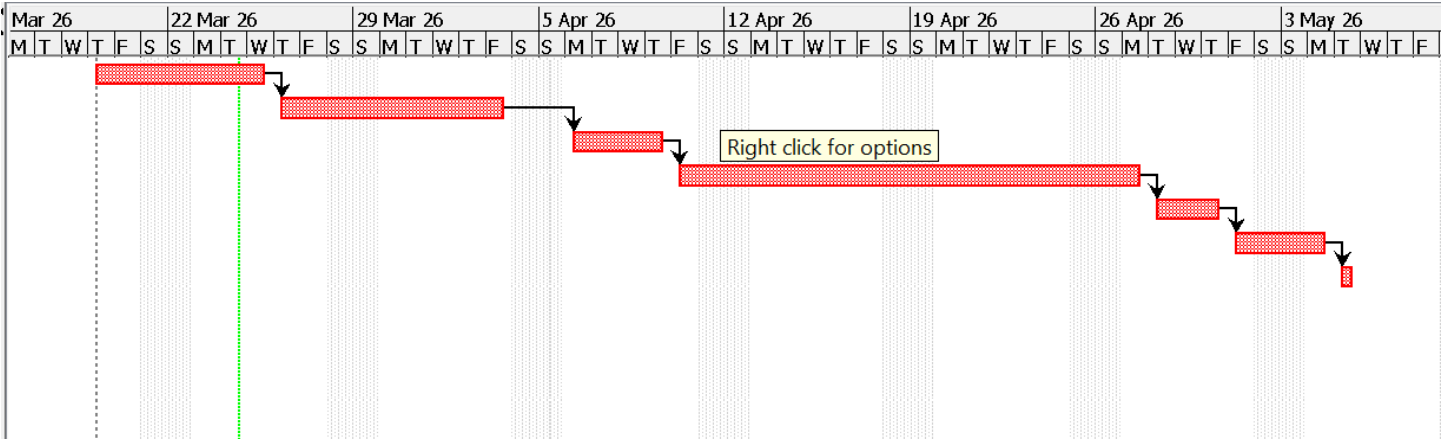
The Goals Screen allows users to set and track financial goals, such as saving for a vacation or purchasing a new item. It displays progress using visual indicators like progress bars, helping users stay motivated and monitor how close they are to achieving their goals.

Navigation Flow



Gantt Chart Design

		Name	Duration	Start	Finish	Predecessors
1		Research	5 days	3/19/26, 8:00 AM	3/25/26, 5:00 PM	
2		Design UI	7 days	3/26/26, 8:00 AM	4/3/26, 5:00 PM	1
3		Setup Project	4 days	4/6/26, 8:00 AM	4/9/26, 5:00 PM	2
4		Develop Features	12 days	4/10/26, 8:00 AM	4/27/26, 5:00 PM	3
5		Testing	3 days	4/28/26, 8:00 AM	4/30/26, 5:00 PM	4
6		Bug Fixing	2 days	5/1/26, 8:00 AM	5/4/26, 5:00 PM	5
7		Final Submission	1 day	5/5/26, 8:00 AM	5/5/26, 5:00 PM	6



Conclusion

The design of Pocket Flow is based on research from existing budgeting apps. By combining simplicity, powerful tools, and engaging features, the app aims to provide users with a better way to manage their finances.

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